functioned normally for a while but was removed subsequently in 1968 and the equipment was returned to the US.

These operations as I said were apparently carried out predominantly by Indian personnel but under the joint auspices and in the know of and with the approval at the highest political level of the Government of India at that time.

Desai also clarified that after Howard Kohn's report, the Indian government had assembled the relevant details and the background of these expeditions with reference to available records and in consultations with the US and Indian agencies that were involved in this project. On the issue of the possible leakage of the nuclear device, Desai made the startling claim that samples of water had been taken up to 1970 and had been under observation for some years but no trace of contamination was detected.

Around the same time, at least two American mountaineering expeditions had been planned for the Nanda Devi sanctuary and the IB was told to keep an eye on the climbers led by M.D. Clark. Since the clearance had been given before the newsbreak, there were some deliberations about whether these expeditions should be stopped at the last minute. But Desai was not in favour of recalling any expedition due to the revelation.

The army pitched in to help and provided six restricted map sheets of Nanda Devi and the Banbasa area to assist the scientists. The maps were subsequently sent to the PMO. Two scientists, P. Abraham and Dr K.C. Pillai, were picked up from Bhabha Atomic Research Centre to carry out the sampling of Ganges waters. In May 1979, the government said the tests of samples of silt and water collected in April 1978 from the upper